Specification of the controlled designation of origin “SANCERRE”

approved by decree no. 2011-1021 of 25 August 2011, JORF of 27 August 2011

CHAPTER I

I. – Name of the designation

Only wines meeting the specific provisions set out below may claim the controlled designation of origin “Sancerre”, initially recognised by the decree of 14 November 1936.

II. – Geographical denominations and complementary terms

The name of the controlled designation of origin may be supplemented by the complementary geographical denomination “Val de Loire” according to the rules fixed in the present specification for the use of this complementary geographical denomination.

III. – Colours and types of product

The controlled designation of origin “Sancerre” is reserved for still white, red and rosé wines.

IV. – Areas and zones in which the various operations are carried out

1° – Geographical area

The harvesting of the grapes, the vinification, the elaboration and the ageing of the wines are carried out within the territory of the following communes of the Cher department: Bannay, Bué, Crézancy-en-Sancerre, Menetou-Râtel, Ménétréol-sous-Sancerre, Montigny, Saint-Satur, Sainte-Gemme-en-Sancerrois, Sancerre, Sury-en-Vaux, Thauvenay, Veaugues, Verdigny, Vinon.

2° – Delimited parcel area

The wines come exclusively from vines situated within the delimited parcel production area as approved by the National Institute of Origin and Quality at the sessions of the competent national committee of 1, 2 and 3 June 1983 and of 29 and 30 August 1990.

The National Institute of Origin and Quality lodges with the town halls of the communes referred to in 1° the graphic documents establishing the parcel boundaries of the production area thus approved.

3° – Immediate proximity area

The immediate proximity area, defined by derogation for the vinification, the elaboration and the ageing of the wines, is made up of the territory of the following communes:

Cher department: Aubinges, Crosses, Henrichemont, Humbligny, Jalognes, Menetou-Salon, Morogues, Neuvy-Deux-Clochers, Parassy, Pigny, Quantilly, Saint-Céols, Soulangis, Vignoux-sous-les- Aix

Loiret department: Beaulieu-sur-Loire, Bonny-sur-Loire, Briare, Gien, Ousson-sur-Loire, Saint- Brisson-sur-Loire, Thou

Nièvre department: Alligny-Cosne, Bulcy, La Celle-sur-Loire, Cosne-Cours-sur-Loire, Garchy, Mesves-sur-Loire, Myennes, Neuvy-sur-Loire, Pougny, Pouilly-sur-Loire, Saint-Andelain, Saint-Laurent-l’Abbaye, Saint-Loup, Saint-Martin-sur-Nohain, Saint-Père, Tracy-sur-Loire

V. – Grape varieties

a) – The white wines come from the sauvignon B variety only.

b) – The red and rosé wines come from the pinot noir N variety only.

VI. – Management of the vineyard

1° – Training methods

a) – Planting density.
The vines present a minimum planting density of 6,100 plants per hectare. These vines may not present a spacing between rows greater than 1.30 metre and a spacing between plants within the same row less than 0.80 metre and greater than 1.25 metre.

b) – Pruning rules.
The vines are pruned: - either in single Guyot with a maximum of 10 free eyes (buds) per plant, of which a maximum of 8 free eyes on the long cane, and one or 2 spurs with a maximum of 2 free eyes; - or in double Guyot with a maximum of 12 free eyes per plant, two canes with a maximum of 4 free eyes, and one or 2 spurs with a maximum of 2 free eyes; - or by short pruning (trained in Royat cordon) with a maximum of 14 free eyes per plant, a single or double framework, bearing spurs with a maximum of 2 free eyes. The establishment period of the cordon is limited to 4 years. During this period, single or double Guyot pruning, with a maximum of 8 free eyes on each long cane, is authorised. The rejuvenation of a vine parcel trained in Royat cordon may not exceed 20 % of the existing plants per year.

c) – Trellising rules and foliage height.
- Trellising is compulsory. - The height of the trellised foliage must be at least equal to 0.6 times the spacing between rows, the height of trellised foliage being measured between a point situated 0.10 metre below the bending wire and the stabilised topping height.

d) – Average maximum load per parcel.
The average maximum load per parcel is fixed at: - 10,500 kilograms per hectare for the white wines; - 9,500 kilograms per hectare for the red and rosé wines.

e) – Threshold for missing vines.
- The percentage of dead or missing vine plants, referred to in Article D. 645-4 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, is fixed at 20 %. - For the vines whose initial planting density is greater than 8,000 plants per hectare, the percentage of dead or missing vine plants, referred to in Article D. 645-4 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code, is fixed at 30 %.

f) – Cultivation condition of the vine.
The parcels are managed so as to ensure a good overall cultivation condition of the vine, in particular its sanitary condition and the upkeep of its soil.

2° – Other cultivation practices

In order to preserve the characteristics of the physical and biological environment that constitutes a fundamental element of the terroir: a) – The slope corrections respect the natural pedological sequence of the parcel; b) – The parcels are managed so as to limit the erosion linked to the runoff of waters; c) – The control of the plant cover, where it exists, of the headlands, embankments and ditches adjacent to the vine parcels is carried out mechanically.

3° – Irrigation

Irrigation is prohibited.

VII. – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes

1° – Harvest

The wines come from grapes harvested at proper ripeness. The start date of the harvest is fixed according to the provisions of Article D. 645-6 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code.

2° – Ripeness of the grapes

a) – Sugar richness of the grapes. The sugar content of the grapes meets the following characteristics:

COLOUR OF THE WINES	MINIMUM SUGAR CONTENT OF THE GRAPES (grams per litre of must)
White wines	170
Red and rosé wines	175

b) – Minimum natural alcoholic strength by volume. The natural alcoholic strength by volume of the wines meets the following characteristics:

COLOUR OF THE WINES	MINIMUM NATURAL ALCOHOLIC STRENGTH BY VOLUME
White wines	10.5 %
Red and rosé wines	10.5 %

VIII. – Yields. – Entry into production

1° – Yield

The yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at:

COLOUR OF THE WINES	YIELD (hectolitres per hectare)
White wines	65
Rosé wines	63
Red wines	59

2° – Limit yield

The limit yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at:

COLOUR OF THE WINES	LIMIT YIELD (hectolitres per hectare)
White wines	75
Rosé wines	69
Red wines	69

3° – Entry into production of young vines

The benefit of the controlled designation of origin may be granted to wines coming from:

- parcels of young vines only from the 2nd year following that in the course of which planting was carried out in place before 31 July;

- parcels of young vines only from the 1st year following that in the course of which grafting in place was carried out before 31 July;

- parcels of vines that have been top-grafted, at the earliest in the 1st year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, and once the parcels no longer contain any varieties other than those permitted for the appellation.

IX. – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage

1° – General provisions

The wines are vinified in accordance with local, fair and constant usages.

a) – Malolactic fermentation. The lots of red wine ready to be marketed in bulk, or at the packaging stage, present a malic acid content less than or equal to 0.3 gram per litre.

b) – Analytical standards. The lots ready to be marketed in bulk, or at the packaging stage, present a content of fermentable sugars (glucose + fructose): - less than or equal to 4 grams per litre for the white and rosé wines; - less than or equal to 2.5 grams per litre for the red wines.

c) – Oenological practices and physical treatments. - For the elaboration of the rosé wines, the use of charcoals for oenological use, alone or in a mixture in preparations, is prohibited; - Any thermal treatment of the harvest involving a temperature greater than 40 °C is prohibited, if it is followed by an immediate separation of the liquid and solid phases; - The use of pieces of wood is prohibited; - For the red wines, the subtractive enrichment techniques are authorised and the maximum rate of partial concentration in relation

to the volumes used is fixed at 10 %; - The wines do not exceed, after enrichment, a total alcoholic strength by volume of 13 %.

d) – Prohibited equipment. The use of continuous presses is prohibited.

e) – Capacity of the vinification vat room. Every operator demonstrates a vinification vat capacity at least equal to 1.4 times the average volume vinified on the holding over the last five years.

f) – Good overall condition of upkeep of the cellar (floor and walls) and of the equipment (hygiene). - The cellar (floors and walls) and the vinification equipment present a good general condition of upkeep. - The vinification equipment is free of apparent iron.

2° – Provisions by type of product

The red wines undergo ageing at least until 1 March of the year following that of the harvest.

3° – Provisions relating to packaging

For each packaged lot, the operator keeps available for the approved control body: - the information appearing in the register of handling operations referred to in Article D. 645-18 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code; - an analysis carried out before or after packaging. The analysis reports must be kept for a period of 6 months from the date of packaging.

4° – Provisions relating to storage

The operator demonstrates a suitable place for the storage of the packaged wines.

5° – Provisions relating to the movement of products and to placing on the market for the consumer

a) – Date of placing on the market for the consumer. - The white and rosé wines are placed on the market for the consumer according to the provisions of Article D. 645-17 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code. - The red wines are placed on the market for the consumer from 15 March of the year following that of the harvest, at the end of the ageing period.

b) – Period during which the wines may not move between approved warehouse keepers. - The white and rosé wines may move between approved warehouse keepers only from 1 December of the year of harvest. - The red wines may move between approved warehouse keepers only from 1 March of the year following that of the harvest.

X. – Link with the geographical area

1° – Information on the geographical area

a) – Description of the natural factors contributing to the link

Situated on the south-eastern edges of the Paris Basin, the geographical area of the controlled designation of origin “Sancerre” rests on a succession of hills whose summits culminate between 200 metres and 400 metres on the left bank of the Loire. The relief, fairly marked, is characterised by important, more or less curved hillsides, with multiple orientations, distributed over 14 communes of the Cher department. The slopes that bear the vineyard, established between 180 metres and 350 metres of altitude, are often very important, with gradients that may, in places, exceed 50 %.

The region is affected by a system of north-south faults, a repercussion of the Alpine uplift, at the origin of a small rift valley that the Loire follows over a part of its course. In particular, the two famous faults known as the “Sancerre fault” and the “Thauvenay fault” cross the vineyard from side to side. They bring into contact the collapsed layers of the Cretaceous and the Eocene with the Jurassic formations of the western part of the geographical area.

The intense erosion has laid bare the bedrock, with the development of three great types of soils on which the parcels selected for the harvesting of the grapes are established: - the marls, also called “terres blanches” (white lands), arising from the Kimmeridgian, which are encountered in particular on the steepest slopes and are recognisable by the thousands of small comma-shaped oyster shells (ostrea virgula); - the soils developed on limestones, called “caillotes” or “cris”, arising from the Oxfordian and

the Portlandian; - the clayey-siliceous soils, called “chailloux” or “silex” (flint), arising from the Cenomanian and the Eocene.

The climate is a degraded oceanic climate. The massif of the “Pays Fort”, to the west of the vineyard, nuances this oceanic characteristic by a foehn effect. The rainfall is around 650 millimetres and characterises an area sheltered from the humid winds, whereas it exceeds 750 millimetres on the hills of the massif of the “Pays Fort”, which culminates at 435 metres. Moreover, the Loire plays a preponderant role as a thermal regulator by draining the cold air of the perpendicular wine valleys. The temperatures, during the vegetative cycle of the vine, are thus attenuated.

b) – Description of the human factors contributing to the link

The vineyard and the wines of Sancerre are cited in the 6th century in the “History of the Franks” of GREGORY OF TOURS, who refers to the abundance of the wines of Sancerre. Raoul TORTAIRE, a monk of Saint-Benoît-sur-Loire, writes, in the 11th century, that the region of Sancerre “abounds with wines”.

Numerous writings of the Renaissance cite the importance of the wine production and the export of a part of these wines towards the countries of the North from the port of Saint-Thibault, in particular towards Flanders and England. In this town, whose river port is well equipped, premises are for rent to store the merchandise. The Abbé POUPARD, parish priest of Sancerre, in his book “Histoire de la ville de Sancerre” in 1777, describes the soils of the Sancerrois: “There is perhaps no terroir more broken up and more differentiated than that of the mountains of the Sancerrois. The ravines, which are multiplied there, offer everywhere veins of different soils”. In this book, he also relates the international trade of the wines: “I have sometimes seen the inhabitants of Sancerre send their wine to England and to Scotland”.

After the phylloxera crisis, the knowledge and the experience of the geographical environment lead the professionals to opt for the choice of a progressive replanting of the vineyard with the sauvignon B variety for the production of white wines and with the pinot noir N variety for the production of the red and rosé wines. As early as 1921, the producers organise themselves around the “Union Viticole Sancerroise”, which has the task of defending the interests of the producers. In 1931, faced with the notoriety already acquired by the wines of “Sancerre” and the existence of wines produced under the name of “Sancerre” without respecting its grape varieties, the producers decide to take the matter to court. By judgment rendered on 20 July 1931, only the wines produced from the sauvignon B and pinot noir N varieties, on the communes of the geographical area, are authorised to be marketed under the name of “Sancerre”. The controlled designation of origin “Sancerre” is recognised by [the decree] of 14 November 1936.

In 1956, the “Comité de Propagande des Vins de Sancerre” is created, which subsequently becomes the “Comité de Promotion des Vins de Sancerre”, a subsidiary of the “Union Viticole Sancerroise”, and which has the task of communication and promotion. In 2009, the production represents a volume of 150,000 hectolitres, for about 2,800 hectares of vines exploited essentially by family businesses. More than 50 % of this production is marketed outside the national territory or exported to more than 100 countries.

2° – Information on the quality and characteristics of the product

The wines are still, dry, with a roundness on the palate and a fresh and well-balanced finish. They may be appreciated in their youth but certain vintages possess a good keeping potential. The white wines, with an often pale-gold robe, decline an aromatic palette that may range from fruity notes recalling citrus or exotic fruits to floral notes recalling white flowers. The rosé wines open onto delicate and fruity aromas. Their robe ranges from pale pink to deep salmon. The red wines display a robe of variable intensity and reveal complex aromas with generally a dominant note of red fruits. Their structure rests on supple and elegant tannins. They are balanced wines, combining power and finesse.

3° – Causal interactions

The conjunction of the degraded oceanic climate, of the situation sheltered from the south-west winds, of the proximity of the Loire which plays a determining role as a thermal regulator, and of the establishment of the vineyard on steep slopes, gives this geographical area good pedo-climatic conditions for the sauvignon B and pinot noir N varieties, varieties of the first period of ripeness. The attenuated temperatures, during the vegetative cycle of the vine, ensure a regular ripeness of the grapes.

According to the usages, the delimited parcel area retains only the shallow soils, on often steep slopes. These situations impose an optimal management of the plant and of its production potential, reflected in a high planting density, in the training of the vine and in a rigorous pruning. This management illustrates the know-how of an obstinate human community, attached to its winegrowing traditions and to its viticultural landscape. This know-how is also expressed by the capacity of the elaborator, acquired from the experience of several generations, to express the richness and the originality of the natural environment: elegant wines, with accents of red fruits and white flowers, of the "caillotes"; powerful wines of the "terres blanches"; wines of the "chailloux" or "silex", with nuances of white and yellow flowers.

The notoriety and the reputation of the wines of "Sancerre", already evoked by Jules GUYOT in 1873 — "At the first glance cast over the vines of Saint-Satur and of Sancerre, one recognises a precious vineyard by the extreme cleanliness of the soil, by the raisings, the tyings and the toppings done with extreme care; one understands that there are here, of long standing, good practices, well repaid by good products" — have not belied themselves since the Renaissance, and the international trade, which has been attached to them since that period, is an excellent illustration thereof.

XI. – Transitional measures

1° – Delimited parcel area

On a transitional basis, the parcels planted with vine excluded from the delimited parcel area of the controlled designation of origin, identified by their cadastral references, their areas and their grape varieties, the list of which was approved by the competent national committee of the National Institute of Origin and Quality at the sessions of 1, 2 and 3 June 1983 and 29 and 30 August 1990, provided that they meet the conditions fixed in the present specification, continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until they are grubbed up.

2° – Training methods

The vine parcels in place on 31 July 2009 whose spacing between plants within the same row is less than 0.80 metre continue to benefit, for their harvest, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until they are grubbed up.

XII. – Rules of presentation and labelling

1° – General provisions

Wines for which, under the terms of the present specification, the controlled designation of origin "Sancerre" is claimed and which are presented under the said appellation may not be declared, after the harvest, offered to the public, dispatched, put up for sale or sold unless, in the harvest declaration, in advertisements, on leaflets, labels, invoices and any containers whatsoever, the aforesaid controlled designation of origin is entered.

2° – Particular provisions

a) – All the optional indications are entered, on the labels, in characters whose dimensions, in height, width and thickness, are not greater than double those of the characters composing the name of the controlled designation of origin.

b) – The dimensions of the characters of the complementary geographical denomination "Val de Loire" are not greater, both in height and in width, than two-thirds of those of the characters composing the name of the controlled designation of origin.

c) – The labelling of the wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin may specify the name of a smaller geographical unit, provided that: - it is a registered cadastral lieu-dit; - it appears on the harvest declaration.

CHAPTER II

I. – Declaration obligations

1. Claim declaration

The claim declaration must be sent to the defence and management body before 25 November of the year of harvest. It indicates: - the designation claimed; - the volume of the wine; - the EVV or SIRET number; - the name and address of the applicant; - the place of storage of the wine. It is accompanied by a copy of the harvest declaration and, as the case may be, a copy of the production declaration or an extract of the stock accounts for buyers of grapes and musts.

2. Declaration of intention of first packaging or first bulk transaction of a wine of a new vintage (form entitled "Declaration of first bottling or movement")

Every operator sends to the defence and management body a declaration of intention of bulk transaction or of packaging, for a new vintage, within a period of five weeks: - before the first exit from the cellar of a lot of bulk wine of the vintage concerned; - before the first packaging of a lot of wine of the vintage concerned. The defence and management body transmits the declaration to the approved control body within a period of forty-eight working hours.

3. Declaration relating to the dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine

Every operator wishing to carry out a dispatch outside the national territory of a non-packaged wine benefiting from the controlled designation of origin must declare it to the approved control body at least five working days before the dispatch.

4. Downgrading declaration

Every operator carrying out a downgrading of wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin must declare it to the defence and management body and to the approved control body within a maximum period of ten working days after this downgrading.

5. Reworking of parcels

Before any development or any works liable to modify the morphology, the subsoil or the arable layer of a delimited parcel intended for the production of the controlled designation of origin, with the exception of classic deep-ploughing works, a declaration is sent by the operator to the defence and management body at least two weeks before the date scheduled for the start of the envisaged works. The defence and management body transmits, without delay, a copy of this declaration to the services of the National Institute of Origin and Quality.

II. – Keeping of registers

1. Cellar plan

Every operator approved for vinification, storage or packaging operations keeps available for the approved control body an up-to-date cellar plan, allowing in particular the number, designation, type and capacity of the containers to be identified.

2. Cellar registers

a) – Every operator packaging wines of the controlled designation of origin keeps up to date a packaging register (form entitled "Register of bottling, enrichment, holding and use of products") indicating for each lot: - the identification of the container(s) of provenance of the wine; - the volume of the lot (expressed, where applicable, in number of bottles); - the date of packaging; - the number of the packaged lot.

b) – Every operator carrying out one or more transactions of non-packaged wines of the controlled designation of origin keeps up to date a register of the removal(s) (form entitled "Monthly summary declaration") indicating in particular for each lot: - the identification of the container(s) of provenance of the wine; - the volume of the lot expressed in hectolitres; - the date of dispatch; - the reference of the recipient and, where applicable, the inter-trade contract number.

CHAPTER III

I. – Main points to be checked and evaluation methods

MAIN POINTS TO BE CHECKED	EVALUATION METHODS
A – STRUCTURAL RULES	

A1 – Belonging of the planted parcels to the delimited area	Documentary checks (up-to-date CVI record) and checks in the field.
A2 – Claimable production potential (grape varieties, monitoring of transitional measures, planting density and trellising)	Documentary checks and checks in the field. For new approvals: verification of the whole of the rules linked to the production potential (grape varieties, density, trellising height, percentage of missing vines) during a visit in the field.
A3 – Processing, ageing, packaging and storage facilities	
Ageing (upkeep of the cellar and equipment)	Checks in the field
Place of vinification	Documentary checks and on-site checks
Traceability of the packaging	Documentary checks (register keeping) and on-site checks
Appropriate storage place	On-site checks
B – RULES LINKED TO THE PRODUCTION CYCLE	
B1 – Management of the vineyard. — Pruning	Counting of the number of free eyes per stock and description of the pruning method
Average maximum load per parcel	Counting of bunches and estimation of the load from an indicative table drawn up for this purpose
Other cultivation practices	Checks at the parcel
B2 – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes. — Monitoring of the harvest date	Verification of the derogations, checks in the field
B3 – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage. — Oenological practices or treatments (enrichment, prohibited practices…)	Documentary checks and on-site checks
Prohibited equipment and upkeep of the equipment	On-site checks
Stock accounts, traceability	Documentary checks (register keeping)
B4 – Harvest declaration and claim declaration	
Missing vines	Documentary checks (register keeping) and visits in the field
Authorised yield	Documentary checks
Claim declaration	Documentary checks and on-site checks (compliance with the arrangements and deadlines, consistency with the harvest declaration, production declaration, etc.). Control of the placing into circulation of the products
C – CHECKS ON THE PRODUCTS	
At removal for the non-packaged wines	Analytical and organoleptic examination
Packaged wines	Analytical and organoleptic examination
Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory	Analytical and organoleptic examination of all the lots
D – PRESENTATION OF THE PRODUCTS	
Labelling	Documentary checks and on-site checks

II – References concerning the control structure

National Institute of Origin and Quality (INAO)
TSA 30003
93555 – MONTREUIL-SOUS-BOIS Cedex

Tel: (33) (0)1.73.30.38.00
Fax: (33) (0)1.73.30.38.04
Email: info@inao.gouv.fr

The check of compliance with the present specification is carried out by a third-party body offering guarantees of competence, impartiality and independence, under the authority of the INAO, on the basis of an approved inspection plan.

The inspection plan sets out the self-checks carried out by the operators on their own activity and the internal checks carried out under the responsibility of the defence and management body. It indicates the external checks carried out by the third-party body as well as the analytical and organoleptic examinations. The whole of the checks is carried out by sampling. Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory are the subject of a systematic analytical and organoleptic check.